

— JAPAN · SAKE EXPORT · MARKET ANALYSIS

Japan Sake Export 2026

Premiumization, tier-1 city distribution channel economics, and the China-US rotation reshaping a JPY 45.9 bn export market growing at a five-year 14% CAGR

MARKET

Japan

INDUSTRY

Sake Export

YEAR

2026

PUBLISHED

June 2026

How we built this view

This view is built from two evidence streams: **primary inputs** — analyst synthesis, importer and on-trade channel checks across the United States and Greater China, and brewery export reads — and **secondary anchors** — customs trade statistics, trade-association export data, listed-brewer filings, and government export strategy targets. Every quantitative claim carries an explicit source tag.

PRIMARY INPUTS

Field channel checks

Conversations with importers, distributors, and on-trade operators across tier-1 export cities — surfaces real placement, price ladders, and velocity for premium grades not visible in headline trade totals.

Analyst synthesis

KIRA in-house triangulation across disclosed inputs: customs trade data, association export releases, and brewery shipment disclosures. Tagged inline as [Kira estimates].

Operator and specialist reads

Input from exporting breweries, cold-chain logistics providers, and overseas sommelier-led accounts closer to the premiumization signal than aggregate export tables.

SECONDARY ANCHORS

Customs and trade authorities

Ministry of Finance Trade Statistics and National Tax Agency export tracking for value, volume, and per-litre unit price by destination — cited inline by named source and period.

Association and brewer filings

Japan Sake and Shochu Makers Association annual export releases; annual reports and shipment disclosures of listed and named breweries — cited inline by source and year.

Triangulated estimates

Where no single source covers a figure, we combine 2–3 inputs and disclose the method. Tagged [Kira estimates]. Approximately 30% of quantitative claims are KIRA-derived; 70% are externally cited.

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Value, not volume — the export story is a premium-price climb.

Sake exports reached **JPY 45.9 bn in 2025**, **+6% YoY**, to a record 81 countries [JSS 2026], with value nearly doubled since 2020 on a **five-year 14% CAGR** [JSS 2026]. The engine is premiumization: per-litre export price has more than doubled over the decade, and growth concentrates in junmai daiginjo and ginjo grades moving through tier-1 city on-trade and specialty retail.

SAKE EXPORTS 2025

JPY 45.9 bn

+6.0% YoY · record 81 markets

JSS 2026

EXPORT VOLUME 2025

33.6 kL

+8% YoY · faster than value

JSS 2026

PRICE PER LITRE, DECADE

¥633 → 1,323

More than doubled · premium mix

MOF 2025

FIVE-YEAR EXPORT CAGR

14%

Value nearly doubled since 2020

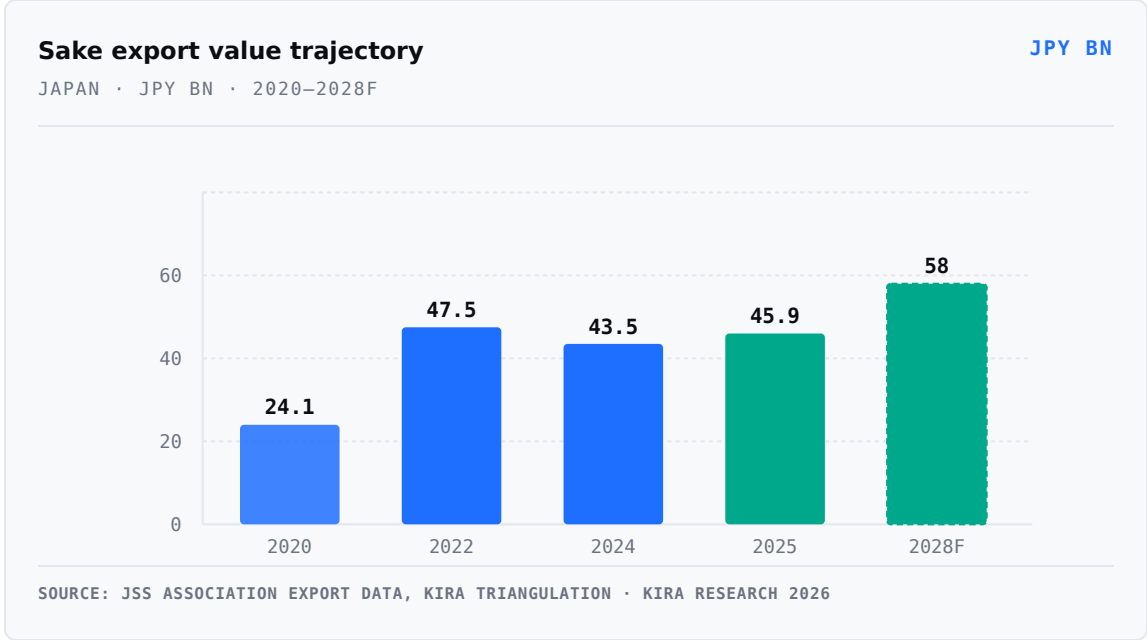
KIRA ESTIMATES

Premium grade is the growth engine

Premium classes — junmai, ginjo, and daiginjo — make up roughly **half of output** and the bulk of export value [JSS 2026]. Per-litre export price climbed from about **JPY 633 to JPY 1,323 over the decade** [MOF 2025], and in China, Hong Kong, and Singapore unit price runs above JPY 2,000/L [NTA 2025]. Volume rose 8% in 2025 while value rose 6% — more bottles at a marginally softer mix as the channel broadens.

UNESCO status anchors the premium narrative

Japan's traditional sake brewing was inscribed on the **UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage list in December 2024** [Nippon 2025], reinforcing a craft, terroir-led story that underwrites premium positioning in overseas on-trade. Export value has gone from ~JPY 10 bn in 2013 to ~JPY 46 bn — a four-fold-plus run over a decade [Nippon 2025].



SOURCE KEY · JSS 2026 = Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association 2025 export release · MOF 2025 = Ministry of Finance Trade Statistics 2025 (per-litre unit price) · NTA 2025 = National Tax Agency sake export tracking 2025 · Nippon 2025 = Nippon.com sake export & UNESCO coverage 2025

Five strategic implications for market participants.

Derived from the structural findings in this report. Each implication is anchored to a quantitative data point that market participants should treat as a **directional signal**, not a point forecast.

01 · Lead with premium grade, not volume Export value rose 6% on 8% more volume in 2025 [JSS 2026] while per-litre price has more than doubled in a decade [MOF 2025]. Brewers should anchor export mix on junmai daiginjo and ginjo, where overseas on-trade pays a craft premium, rather than chasing table-grade litres. ANCHOR: ¥1,323/L export price, doubled in a decade [MOF 2025]	02 · Treat China and the US as a rotation China returned to #1 at JPY 13.3 bn (+13.9%) in 2025 after a 2024 dip; the US held near JPY 11-12 bn [JSS 2026]. The two markets move counter-cyclically; participants should balance allocation across both rather than over-index a single tier-1 demand pool. ANCHOR: JPY 13.3 bn China 2025, back to #1 [JSS 2026]	03 · Price through the new US tariff A 15% value-based US tariff took effect August 2025, on top of the prior per-litre duty [JFN 2025]. Importers and brewers should rebuild landed-cost ladders and protect shelf price on premium SKUs where elasticity is lowest, absorbing less at the table grade. ANCHOR: 15% US value tariff from Aug 2025 [JFN 2025]	04 · Own the tier-1 on-trade door Restaurants and izakaya carry roughly 45% of global sake sales; specialty retail ~37% [Market reads 2025]. The premium discovery occasion is on-premise; brewers should fund sommelier-led placement in tier-1 cities before pushing into mass retail. ANCHOR: ~45% sales via on-trade globally [Market reads 2025]	05 · Automate against toji succession Brewery count fell ~40% over 30 years as master brewers age out [Jakarta Post 2024]. AI fermentation models and IoT sensing preserve tacit craft and stabilize quality at export scale; the first payback is consistency, then labour cost. ANCHOR: ~40% brewery decline over 30 years [Jakarta Post 2024]
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SECTION 01

Export sizing & unit price

Exports have nearly doubled since 2020, but the engine is price, not litres: **per-litre export value has more than doubled over the decade** as premium grades carry the climb — a market sized by craft positioning and tier-1 demand, not by bulk shipment.

TOTAL VALUE 2025

VOLUME VS VALUE

PER-LITRE PRICE CLIMB

PREMIUM MIX

A price-led climb: value doubled in five years, litres lagged.

Sake export value reached **JPY 45.9 bn in 2025, +6% YoY**, on volume of 33.6k kL, +8% [JSS 2026]. Over five years value nearly doubled at a **14% CAGR** [JSS 2026]; over the decade per-litre price more than doubled, the clearest signal that premiumization — not bulk volume — is the structural driver.

Value runs ahead of volume long-term

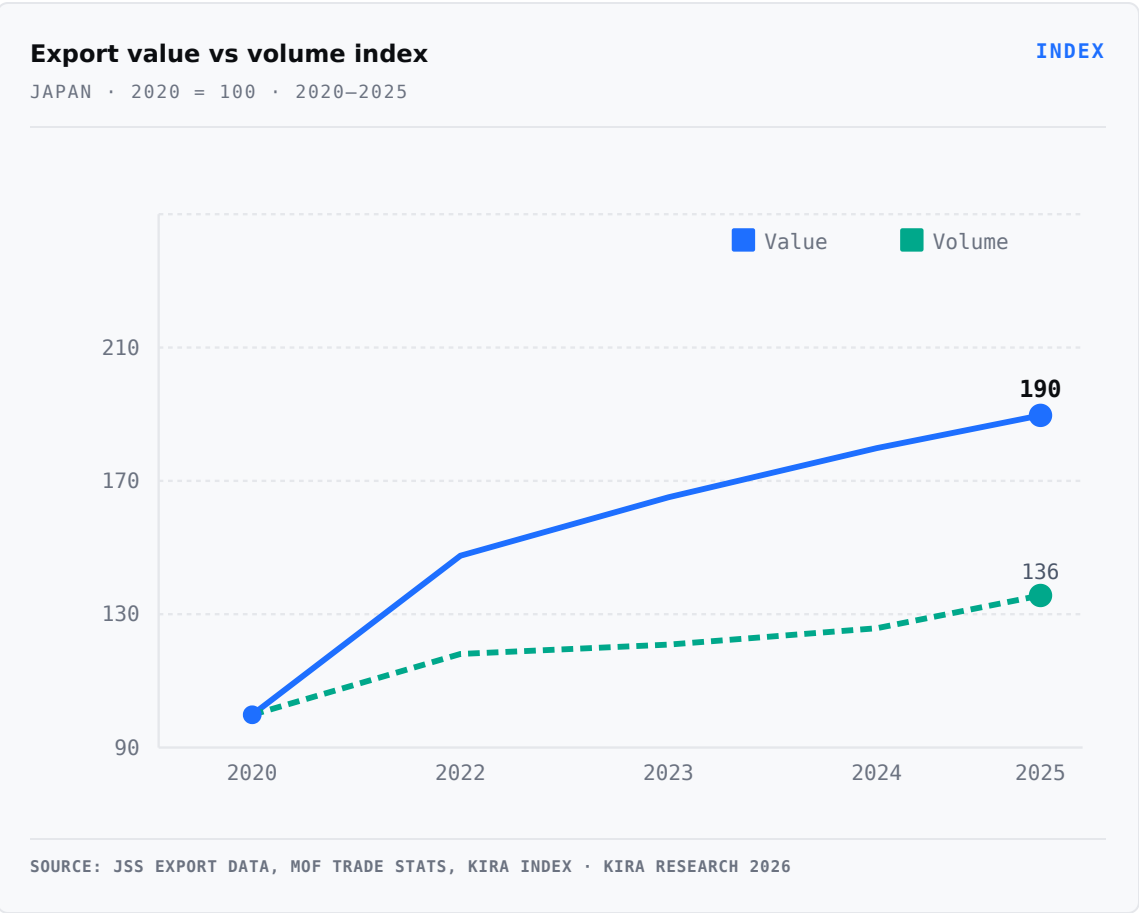
Across the decade, export value grew faster than litres as the mix shifted to premium grades [JSS 2026]. In 2025 the gap inverted briefly — volume +8% against value +6% [JSS 2026] — as the destination footprint widened to 81 markets and entry-tier bottles broadened reach. The **structural trend remains price-led**: premium discovery seeds volume that later trades up.

Per-litre price has more than doubled

Average export price rose from about **JPY 633 to JPY 1,323 per litre** over ten years [MOF 2025]. In China, Hong Kong, and Singapore, unit price holds above **JPY 2,000/L** [NTA 2025] — the high-spend tier-1 pools where junmai daiginjo and aged sake command a premium.

Premium grade is roughly half of output

Junmai, ginjo, and daiginjo classes account for around **half of total sake output** and the bulk of export value [JSS 2026]. The path to the government's export target is paved by premium reformulation and craft storytelling, not by reviving a structurally declining domestic table-sake base [Kira estimates].



SOURCE KEY • JSS 2026 = Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association 2025 export release • MOF 2025 = Ministry of Finance Trade Statistics 2025 (per-litre unit price) • NTA 2025 = National Tax Agency sake export tracking 2025

China reclaims the top spot; the US and Korea set fresh records.

Three destinations — China, the US, and Hong Kong — carry roughly **65% of export value** [NTA 2025]. China rebounded to #1 at **JPY 13.3 bn (+13.9%) in 2025** after a 2024 dip [JSS 2026], while the US, Korea, France, and the EU as a whole hit record levels — evidence the base is broadening beyond a Greater-China dependence.

China and the US move in rotation

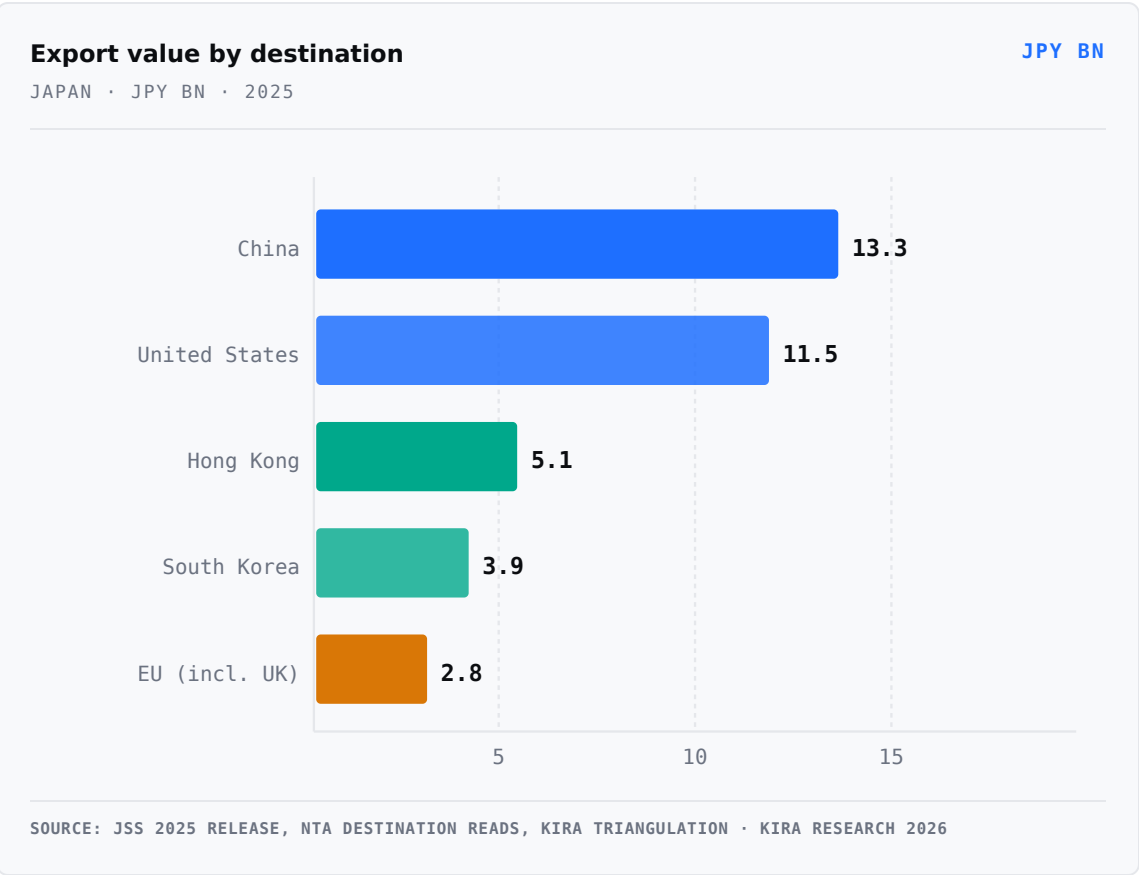
In 2024 China fell to **~JPY 11.7 bn (−6.3%)** on a high-end restaurant slowdown while the US leapt **+25.9% to ~JPY 11.4 bn** [JSS 2025], nearly pulling level. In 2025 the cycle reversed: China rose 13.9% to **JPY 13.3 bn** as excess inventory cleared [JSS 2026]. The two pools offset, smoothing aggregate growth.

Records broaden the base

Korea hit a record **~JPY 3.75 bn (+29.1%)** in 2024 [JSS 2025], and the EU including the UK reached a record **~JPY 2.72 bn** [JSS 2025]. France and other European markets set fresh highs in 2025 [Nippon 2026]. The destination count reached a record **81 countries** [JSS 2026] — diversification is the strategic hedge against any single market's cycle.

Hong Kong softens as a re-export hub

Hong Kong slipped to **~JPY 5.1 bn (−15%)** in 2024 [NTA 2025], partly a re-export pass-through to mainland China rather than end-demand. Its unit price stays among the highest, anchoring the premium tier even as headline value cools [Kira estimates].



SOURCE KEY · JSS 2026 = Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association 2025 export release · JSS 2025 = same association 2024 export release · NTA 2025 = National Tax Agency sake export tracking 2025 · Nippon 2026 = Nippon.com 2025 sake export coverage

SECTION 02

The tier-1 on-trade door

Premium sake is discovered on-premise. Restaurants and izakaya carry **~45% of global sake sales**, and the tier-1 city sommelier account is where junmai daiginjo earns its price — making channel placement, not bulk distribution, the decisive export lever.

ON-TRADE DISCOVERY

SPECIALTY RETAIL

IMPORTER MARGIN

COLD-CHAIN ECONOMICS

On-trade discovers the premium; retail and e-commerce scale it.

Across export markets, restaurants and izakaya account for roughly **45% of sake sales** and retail outlets ~37% [Market reads 2025]. The premium occasion is on-premise: tier-1 city Japanese, fusion, and fine-dining accounts seed discovery, after which specialty retail and online channels convert trial into repeat at-home purchase.

On-trade is the discovery engine

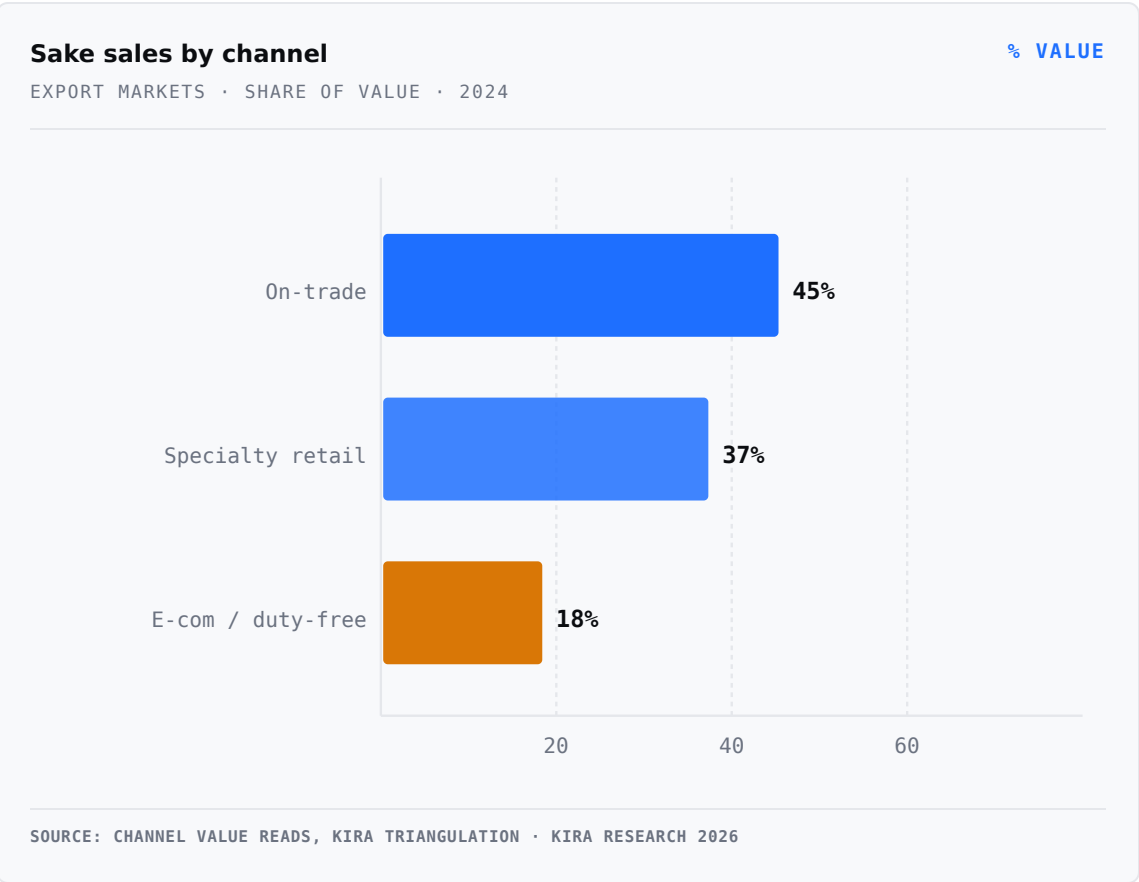
Sake-focused bars and izakaya in cities outside Japan have introduced premium grades to a wider, affluent clientele [Market reads 2025]. The **sommelier-led by-the-glass pour** is the highest-leverage placement — it converts a curious diner into a brand loyalist at a price point that absorbs landed cost and tariff. On-premise is where craft storytelling pays.

Cold-chain shapes landed economics

Premium sake needs **temperature-controlled logistics** to preserve quality, and shipping costs rose ~8% in a recent year [Market reads 2025]. With the August 2025 US tariff adding a 15% value duty [JFN 2025], landed cost compounds — favouring higher-priced SKUs where the percentage burden is more easily absorbed in shelf price.

The importer holds the gatekeeper margin

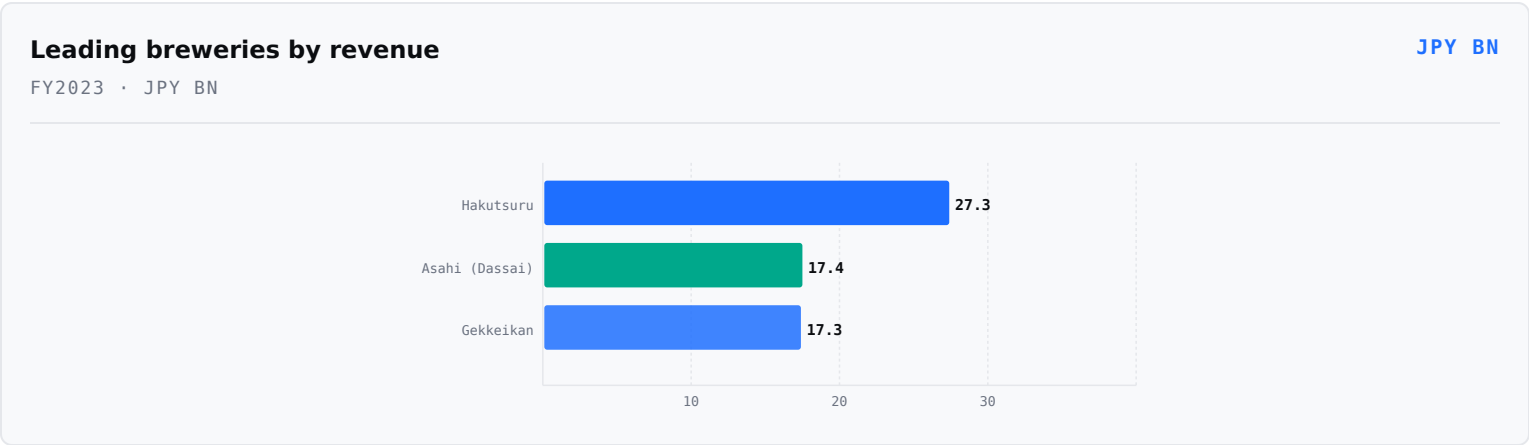
Multi-hop distribution — brewery to importer to distributor to on-trade or retail — stacks margin at each link [Kira estimates]. The importer-distributor sets placement and price ladder; brewers that co-fund education and account activation, rather than ship-and-forget, capture more of the premium they create.



SOURCE KEY • Market reads 2025 = compiled sake-market channel & logistics reads 2024–2025 (on-trade / retail share, cold-chain cost) • JFN 2025 = Japan Food News US tariff & duty-free coverage 2025

Scale brewers anchor; a craft-export champion sets the pace.

The top breweries by revenue — Hakutsuru, Asahi Shuzo, and Gekkeikan — cluster near **JPY 17-27 bn in sales each** [Industry reads 2024], but export intensity, not domestic scale, defines the winners. Asahi Shuzo's Dassai draws **~43% of revenue from export** [Industry reads 2024] and now brews locally in New York.



Scale at home, export at the margin

Hakutsuru leads on domestic revenue at **~JPY 27.3 bn**, but Asahi Shuzo's export-led model is the pace-setter abroad [Industry reads 2024]. The export base is a fragmented long tail of regional craft breweries riding the premium wave.

Dassai export share of revenue	~43%
Breweries exporting (30+ ctry)	scale few
Total exporting destinations	81

EXPORT LEADER

EXPORT PACE-SETTER

Asahi Shuzo (Dassai)

Yamaguchi · junmai daiginjo focus

FY revenue

~¥17.4 bn

Export share

~43%

Markets

30+ ctry

Export-native craft.

Junmai daiginjo brand with a New York local brewery; targets ~50% export share [Industry reads 2024].

SCALE LEADER

Hakutsuru

Hyogo · national packaged sake

FY revenue

~¥27.3 bn

Position

#1 revenue

Focus

broad range

Domestic scale and reach.

Largest brewer by sales [Industry reads 2024]; breadth across table and premium grades anchors volume distribution.

LOCAL PRODUCTION

Gekkeikan

Kyoto · US California brewery

FY revenue

~¥17.3 bn

US site

Folsom CA

Supply

US + Asia

Onshore hedge.

California junmai production serves the US, Canada, and Asia [Industry reads 2024] — a structural buffer against import tariffs.

THE LONG TAIL

Regional craft breweries

Niigata, Yamagata, others

Export model

premium niche

Channel

on-trade led

Brands

terroir story

Craft diversity.

Niigata and Yamagata breweries pursue sommelier-led premium placement; partnerships like Hakkaisan-Brooklyn Kura test US local brewing.

SOURCE KEY · Industry reads 2024 = compiled brewery revenue rankings, export-share disclosures & local-production filings 2023–2024

AI lands first where toji succession and quality risk bite hardest.

Japan's brewery count fell **~40% over 30 years** as master brewers (toji) age out without successors [Jakarta Post 2024]. For an export model that lives on craft consistency, the first AI payback is operational — capturing tacit fermentation knowledge and stabilizing quality at scale — not consumer-facing novelty.

Succession risk forces knowledge capture

Generative AI integrates the tacit knowledge of toji with fermentation metrics and aroma-compound analyses to propose optimal brewing conditions [OpenPR 2025]. Asahi Shuzo's collaboration with a major IT firm built a predictive model that analyzes decades of tank-temperature, polishing-ratio, and yeast data to suggest adjustments — decision support, not replacement [Jakarta Post 2024].

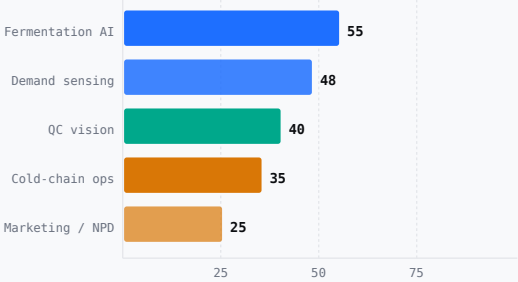
Consistency is the export payback

One AI-led brewer reports a **~40% labour-cost reduction** with higher quality stability via IoT sensors and AI-optimized fermentation [WhaTech 2025]. For export buyers paying a premium, batch-to-batch consistency protects brand equity; the wider food-and-beverage AI market continues to expand, Asia-Pacific leading [F&B AI 2025].

AI adoption readiness by use case

% ADOPT

SAKE EXPORT • SHARE AT SCALE BY 2030 • EST.



SOURCE: KIRA OPERATOR READS & ADOPTION TRIANGULATION • KIRA RESEARCH 2026

BREWERY DECLINE, 30 YRS

~-40%

Toji aging, succession gap

JAKARTA POST 2024

AI BREWER LABOUR SAVING

~40%

With higher quality stability

WHATECH 2025

HIGHEST-RETURN USE CASE

Ferment

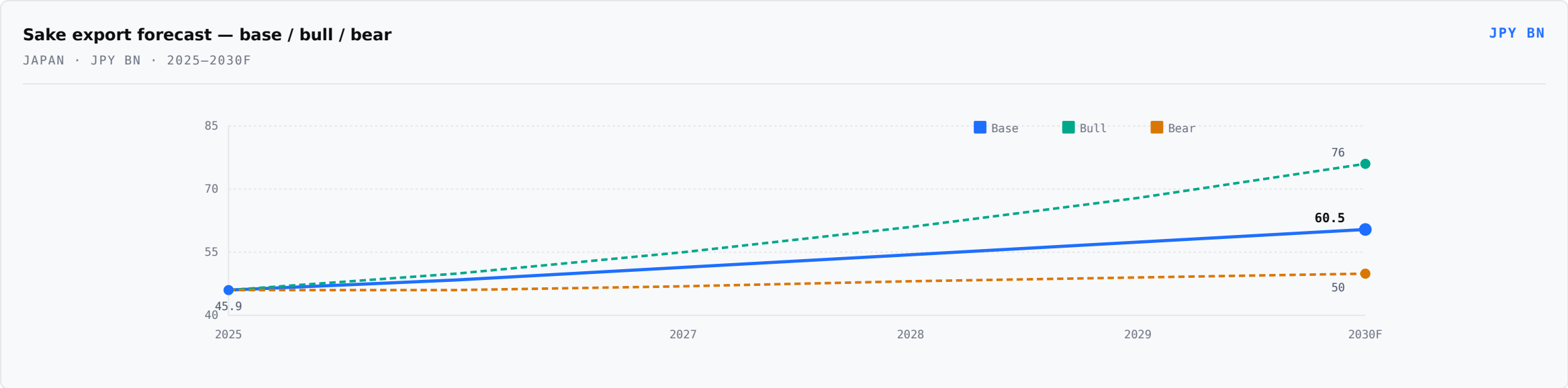
Consistency protects premium

KIRA ESTIMATES

SOURCE KEY • Jakarta Post 2024 = Jakarta Post / AFP sake digital-era brewing report 2024 • WhaTech 2025 = WhaTech AI-driven sake brewing case 2025 • OpenPR 2025 = OpenPR AI in sake brewing & branding 2025 • F&B AI 2025 = AI in Food & Beverages market sizing 2025

Toward JPY 60–76 bn by 2030 — a premium climb against tariff and demand drag.

Our base case tracks exports toward **~JPY 60 bn by 2030**, short of the government's JPY 76 bn export-strategy target [MAFF 2025] but well above 2025's JPY 45.9 bn [JSS 2026]. The variance is set by three levers: the China-US demand rotation, the US tariff pass-through, and how far premium grade penetrates new markets.



BASE · MOST LIKELY

JPY 60_{bn}

Premium mix and market diversification sustain a high-single-digit climb; exports reach **~JPY 60 bn by 2030** [Kira estimates], below the JPY 76 bn target [MAFF 2025] but a continued record path.

BULL · UPSIDE

JPY 76_{bn}

China and US both run hot, UNESCO halo broadens premium reach, and tariff pass-through proves benign; exports hit the **government JPY 76 bn target by 2030** [MAFF 2025], with the EU and Korea over-delivering.

BEAR · DOWNSIDE

JPY 50_{bn}

A prolonged China high-end slump and a sticky US tariff compress premium demand; exports stall near **~JPY 50 bn by 2030** [Kira estimates] as volume growth outpaces value and unit price softens.

SOURCE KEY · MAFF 2025 = Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry & Fisheries export expansion strategy (JPY 76 bn sake target by 2030) · JSS 2026 = Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association 2025 export release

Methodology endnote and source mix

HOW TO READ THE NUMBERS

This view triangulates two evidence streams. Where a figure carries a **named source tag** — for example [JSS 2026], [MOF 2025], [MAFF 2025] — the underlying data comes from that source, with the full citation listed opposite. Where a figure carries **[Kira estimates]**, our analysts derived it from a blend of disclosed inputs — association export releases, customs trade data, brewery filings, and importer channel checks — using the method noted in the relevant section.

Approximately **30% of quantitative claims are KIRA-derived**; 70% are externally cited. Export value and volume are reported on the trade-association and customs basis; destination shares are KIRA reads triangulated across customs data and are directional. Channel value shares reflect global sake-market composition and are directional, not audited.

Currency: figures are JPY unless marked USD. The five-year CAGR references 2020–2025 export value. Forecast scenarios are KIRA constructions anchored to the published government export target and recent trajectory.

SOURCE LIST

JSS 2026	— Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association, 2025 export results release (value, volume, 81 markets)
JSS 2025	— Japan Sake & Shochu Makers Association, 2024 export results release (record 80 markets)
MOF 2025	— Ministry of Finance, Trade Statistics 2025 (per-litre export unit price)
NTA 2025	— National Tax Agency, sake export trend tracking 2025 (destination unit price)
MAFF 2025	— Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry & Fisheries, export expansion strategy (JPY 76 bn sake target by 2030)
Nippon 2025 / 2026	— Nippon.com, sake export & UNESCO inscription coverage 2025–2026
JFN 2025	— Japan Food News, US tariff & duty-free trend coverage 2025
Market reads 2025	— compiled sake-market channel & logistics reads 2024–2025
Jakarta Post 2024	— Jakarta Post / AFP, sake digital-era brewing report 2024
WhaTech 2025	— WhaTech, AI-driven sake brewing case study 2025
OpenPR 2025	— OpenPR, AI in sake brewing & branding 2025
F&B AI 2025	— AI in Food & Beverages global market sizing 2025
Industry reads 2024	— compiled brewery revenue rankings & export-share disclosures 2023–2024

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